

Fidayeen from the sea

Did the Mumbai police ignore warnings about seaborne terrorism given nearly two years ago?

For a coastal city that realised its fortunes from being the maritime gateway of India, the worst misfortunes have also been visited upon Mumbai from the sea. In March 1993, shipments of RDX offloaded south of the city wreaked havoc. In November 2008, it is the possibility of heavily armed terrorists being offloaded from 'mother vessels' like dhows to penetrate an unguarded city coast. This seaborne incursion makes sense in the light of an Intelligence Bureau input received by the Mumbai Police in December 2006. The contents, gleaned from interrogation of militants in Kashmir, were shocking because they alluded to a new form of seaborne terror which has ominous portents for India's unguarded coastal cities. The input, a copy of which is with INDIA TODAY, said that the ISI and Pakistan Navy is training terrorists for seaborne infiltration. Approximately 500 to 600 terrorists had been trained to infiltrate, disguised as fishermen. The warning elaborates 12 to 18 months of training divided into three phases: swimming lessons, handling large boats, laying mines on coasts and planting explosives under bridges and ships. In the last phase, they are taught sea navigation—using GPS, reading the wind, waves, tides and currents, rescue operations, surveillance and concealing explosives.

The Palestinian Hamas have used the sea route to penetrate Israel for attacks; so has the LTTE in Sri Lanka. They are the only terror groups which have used the sea. Pakistan-based terrorist groups Lashkar-e-Toiba, Hizbul Mujahideen, Jaish-e-Mohammed and Harkat-ul-Mujahideen, who were trained by the ISI, were forced to do so after heavily guarded land frontiers have made infiltration difficult. The strikes, however, raise questions on how they passed through the cordon of the navy and coast guard who have patrolled the coast since the March 1993 blasts under 'Operation Swan'. "India is the only country where legislation prohibits the navy and the coast guard from intercepting vessels," says Vice-Admiral Arun Kumar Singh, former director-general, Coast Guard. Clearly, another case of a lethargic security apparatus being caught napping by wily terrorists.

by Sandeep Unnithan



INFLATABLE SPEED BOAT USED BY TERRORISTS TO LAND IN MUMBAI



THE KILLING OF ATS CHIEF HEMANT KARKARE (ABOVE) WAS A MAJOR BLOW

with bullets or have a grenade lobbed at them any time," says a Home Ministry official.

The Pakistan Factor: The attack on Mumbai will impose fresh strains on Indo-Pakistan relations. It came just after a meeting between the two foreign ministers where India talked tough on terror. While intelligence sources see an imprint of the Lashkar-e-Toiba in the attack, interrogation of an arrested terrorist confirmed that they were Pakistani nationals. It comes after the attack on the Indian Embassy in Kabul where a Pakistani link has been proved. This strike was intended to damage the ongoing peace process. The Lashkar continues to run its operations in Pakistan, and recently, much to India's anger, Pakistan had cleared the purchase of a bullet-proof Land Cruiser for Jamaat-ud-Daawa supremo Haafiz Mohammed Syed, who is the ideologue for Lashkar and has been holding rallies asking followers to hit Western targets.

Terror's New Strategy: The strategy is clear: cripple India's economic nerve centre, create fear among tourists and foreign investors and undermine India's global image. The suicide squad has chosen high-profile five-star hotels to capture international attention since they are frequented by Western delegations and tourists. Apart from sending a message to the Government of India, it was a signal to the international community about the strength of terror groups in the region and was also intended to target opinion makers and movers and shakers who frequent these hotels. "It was a daredevil act and certainly had collusion of a terror group like the Al-Qaeda, along with some Pakistan-based terror groups aimed at creating high visibility with panic," remarked a senior official.